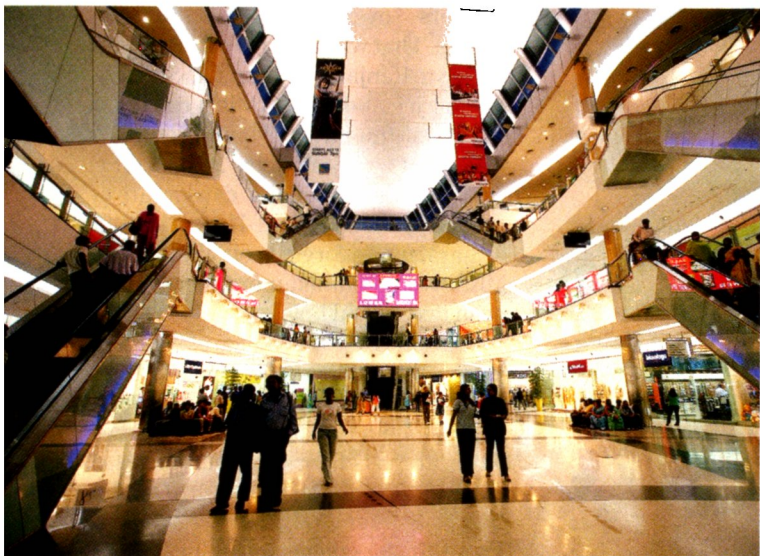


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WEST BENGAL IS WELCOMING SHOPPING MALLS AND NIGHTCLUBS, INDICATING A NEW WILLINGNESS TO DISCARD LEFTIST IDEOLOGY

being crowned the darling of the masses ahead of Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru despite his regional presence. Netaji remained a leftist to the average Bengali and the attachment to him was far greater than that of the nationalist-only Nehru and, by inference, Gandhi, who was seen as somebody who stood diametrically opposite to Netaji's politics.

The Left just does not fit into the social scheme of present-day Kolkata in particular, and Bengal, in general. In the last decade, the influx of non-Bengalis has outnumbered the indigenous populace by a huge margin of around 7 per cent. With that has come consumerism and the mall culture, something totally inimical to the Left mindset. Rahul Roy, 28, a Bengali and a first generation entrepreneur who has just launched a high-end spa in Kolkata, has his basics cut out. He says, "I am an entrepreneur, not a Bengali entrepreneur. This is where Bengalis went wrong. They thrived on family business."

Come elections and the demographic changes are most evident by the response of political parties. Says Gopal Bhadra, a Trinamool activist and poll manager, "The highrises are a sure sign of changing times. I have been in politics for 30 years and used

to paint wall graffiti for Congress leaders. The walls are not there any longer. Bungalows have given way to high-rises. You will find all communities, all religions living in them. So now, instead of graffiti, we focus on community hall programmes or meetings where we try and give a pan-India look to our campaign. And in rich areas, this worked hugely to our advantage."

Graffiti, another Left instrument that once covered the walls of Kolkata with war cries like "China's chairman is our chairman" and "Go back, McNamara" to the openly militant, "Power flows from the barrel of the gun" has now disappeared from the city. Says painter Shuvaprasanna, "Graffiti was an art. Like everything else, the CPI(M)'s graffiti is a shadow of its former self. Like the party, graffiti too has become a fly in the wall."

Leftist aspirations, not only from a



MAHASWETA DEVI, author

“The Left has ceased to exist. The Left by definition is pro-people, now it is pro-rich.”

political standpoint, have touched rock-bottom. The exodus from schools to colleges outside the state is overwhelming. The main cause is the way the Left Front had monopolised the teaching fraternity of Bengal, leading to corruption, nepotism and a warped sense of Communism pervading the corridors of education. "The urge to break free has prevailed and students are leaving the state in hordes, never to return again. This again has been a slow erosion of the Left mindset. Earlier, everything about Bengal was seen as good and better than the rest. Today's youngsters have realised that is not the case," says Krishna Damani, administrator of one of the biggest schools in Asia, South Point School.

Left intellectual Debesh Roy, however, insists that nothing much has changed. "Today's leftist is different. He can dance to Michael Jackson. In our times, dancing to Elvis was taboo. Not any longer. For the young leftist now, Neruda is not the only poet to be read. They also study reactionary poets. That is what political vision is all about," he says.

So, it is back to the future. Where now, the Bengali? Filmmaker Aparna Sen says, "I do not know Mamata Banerjee. But from what I feel and gather, I think she has her heart in the right place." Which is, and anybody's guess is as good as the Bengali's, right there in the Left. ■